‘Hi, I am Shyam Tekwani. Photographer.’ He extended his hand for a shake.

Anirudhya was happy to meet Tekwani. He was famous for his coverage of the mutilation of IPKF soldiers at the hands of LTTE members in 1987. He shook Tekwani’s hand with pleasure. ‘Come inside,’ the photographer took him to his cabin. It didn’t take Anirudhya long to figure out the top brass of Tamil Nadu Police with Tekwani’s help. He suggested that Anirudhya meet IG R.K. Raghavan. He was overall in charge of the security arrangements at Sriperumbudur.

The IG’s office took Anirudhya’s contact details in Madras and said it would get back to him.

Next day, Anirudhya visited his alma mater and met some of the staff from his time. Next was a trip to Marina beach to have coconut water; then to one of the Velu Military food joints for ‘mutton fry’ with ‘lachha paratha’ before getting back to the hotel. The receptionist handed him the room key with four messages—three from Harpal Singh, the editorial coordinator at the Delhi office. He was checking about the progress in work. The fourth message was from Bobb, which just said, ‘Call back.’

Anirudhya felt he had had it. What would he tell Singh or Bobb? The last thing he would like to say was that his ‘sources’ were unavailable to talk to him, giving the impression that he was on a paid vacation. He called Singh first, who told Anirudhya that he need not worry if he had nothing to file that night—it happened often to reporters—and hung up. Anirudhya didn’t tell Singh that Bobb had asked him to call back. Then he called on Bobb’s direct line. Bobb picked up but did not speak. Anirudhya could hear Bobb’s baritone voice yelling at someone. Gosh, he was in a bad mood. Anirudhya thought of hanging up, but suddenly Bobb came on the line.

‘Yeah?’

‘A-anirudhya here. Can we t-talk?’

‘Oh, hi ... Yeah, go right ahead.’

‘I don’t have much to file today ... Actually, still catching up with my sources. They are extremely busy.’